

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Childcare and Early Education English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Childcare workers, early educators, classroom assistants, and preschool support staff.

All children, families, observations, times, and center arrangements are fictional English practice. This is not medical, developmental-diagnostic, safeguarding, legal, nutrition, staffing-ratio, or emergency-response training. Real care plans, supervision, collection authority, reporting duties, and health or protection concerns require current local rules and the center's qualified leadership. Do not infer universal age expectations, clinical advice, or permission to release a child from these exercises. Role titles vary: key educator may be called key person or primary caregiver; designated safeguarding lead means this fictional center's named child-protection contact, not a universal U.S. role. Reasonable adjustment and reasonable accommodation are regional terms with jurisdiction-specific meanings and responsibilities.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Arrivals and family partnerships

Resolve a settling-in mismatch while including the child in the conversation.

02 Play-based learning and useful prompts

Use prompts that help children explain and compare their own ideas.

03 Daily routines and supported transitions

Negotiate a stopping point without offering a false choice about the entire schedule.

04 Co-regulation and peer disagreements

Help children express needs and agree a concrete next step.

05 Observation and family progress conversations

Describe an observed learning moment and keep wider claims proportionate.

06 Inclusive participation and home languages

Compare response formats fairly and respect agreed access support.

07 Health records and factual incident handovers

Report the source and status of health information clearly.

08 Collection, confidentiality, and safeguarding communication

Explain an unverified collection arrangement without accusing the adult or inventing legal rules.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Arrivals and family partnerships

Resolve a settling-in mismatch while including the child in the conversation.

CASE

It is Mina's third morning. Her parent expected to stay for ten minutes, but the arrival note says a brief goodbye. Key educator Rosa is present and can clarify the settling-in plan with the parent. Mina has a familiar cloth; its use follows the center's arrangements.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the parent's expectation and address the child warmly. Agree what happens today without making a guarantee about tears or separation. Do not treat one difficult arrival as evidence about the family. Some settings call the key educator a key person or primary caregiver; check the center's own role names.

Vocabulary to check: key educator, settling-in period, family handover, comfort item.

Model response

You expected ten minutes together, while our arrival note says a brief goodbye. Let's check that difference with Rosa, Mina's key educator, before describing today's plan. Mina, you brought your cloth. Let's talk to Rosa together before you say goodbye.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision creates a shared understanding rather than blaming the parent.

Second-round challenge

Ask for a promise that Mina will not cry after goodbye.

Language-check answers

1. D - key educator Correct. Rosa is the designated continuing family contact here.
2. D - guarantee Correct. Guarantee would promise an outcome we cannot establish.

05 • Conversations

1. Mina's third morning - Fictional arrival conversation using the lesson case.

2. The morning update is from home - Fictional arrival handover; parent reports a disrupted night without requesting medical advice.

3. A name pronounced correctly - Fictional first-week family conversation; educator checks the child's name.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A different adult at drop-off

Amir arrives with his grandparent instead of his parent. The grandparent can share the morning update but does not know the agreed settling-in plan. Key educator Rosa is present and has the plan.

Role A: Educator: welcome Amir and clarify the plan with Rosa.

Role B: Grandparent: you were asked to bring Amir but cannot confirm a change to the goodbye routine.

Possible opening: I usually don't do drop-off. Should I stay, or say goodbye now?

Success checks

- Use Amir's own agreed plan, not another family's arrangement.
- Include the grandparent's useful morning information.
- Check uncertainty with Rosa without criticizing anyone.

Add a complication: A nearby family offers its own goodbye arrangement as the rule for everyone.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Play-based learning and useful prompts

Use prompts that help children explain and compare their own ideas.

CASE

In fictional block play, Eva and Jo each want their bridge design used. Eva wants a wide bridge; Jo wants a taller opening. The educator can invite both explanations and suggest trying two designs using available blocks. No winner has been chosen.

Teach this move

An open-ended question invites more than a guessed adult answer. Scaffolding offers enough help to continue while leaving meaningful choices with children. Adult language can be clear without directing every action.

Vocabulary to check: child-initiated play, guided play, scaffolding, open-ended question.

Model response

Eva, you want a wider bridge; Jo, you want a taller opening. Let's hear what each design would help you do. We have enough blocks to try both ideas, so we don't need to choose a winner first. Tell each other what you want to test, and then decide which design to build first together.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The new question retains the children's ideas and gives discussion a practical purpose.

Second-round challenge

Ask the educator to name the best design before either has been tried.

Language-check answers

1. A - What might make the bridge steadier? Correct. It invites suggestions rather than one fixed answer.
2. B - scaffolding Correct. A temporary hint supports the child's own continuing effort.

05 • Conversations

1. Two bridges worth trying - Fictional educator and child spokesperson discuss the lesson's two-design case.
2. A shop in the play corner - Fictional guided-play exchange; child designs a pretend shop.
3. When a prompt became an instruction - Fictional colleague discussion about scaffolding in child-initiated play.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A pretend menu with several languages

Two children make a pretend cafe. One wants picture labels; another wants words used at home. Both can choose materials from the same table. The educator can invite both ideas without correcting their home language.

Role A: Educator: ask what each label should help customers understand.

Role B: Child: you want pictures but are curious about your friend's home-language words.

Possible opening: Can our menu have pictures and my friend's words, or do we have to choose?

Success checks

- Invite the purpose of each child's choice.
- Allow multiple ways to represent meaning.
- Offer a prompt without replacing the children's menu with an adult design.

Add a complication: Another child says only printed English counts as a real menu.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Daily routines and supported transitions

Negotiate a stopping point without offering a false choice about the entire schedule.

CASE

Luca is building when the room moves to story time in five minutes. The center's current arrangement allows his structure to remain on the marked shelf. He can choose to place the last block or ask the educator to photograph the work using the center's permitted practice. The educator cannot extend play indefinitely.

Teach this move

A bounded choice gives meaningful options while keeping the known routine explicit. Use before and after carefully. Do not threaten, shame, or promise unlimited extra time.

Vocabulary to check: transition, visual schedule, transition cue, self-help skill.

Model response

Luca, story time begins in five minutes. You can place your last block, or we can make a record of your building using our classroom photo arrangement. The structure can stay on the marked shelf. Which would help you finish for now? We will still join the story when the transition cue sounds.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The choice concerns the transition, not whether a fixed routine exists.

Second-round challenge

Ask for ten more minutes when only five are available.

Language-check answers

1. C - afterward Correct. Afterward places snack after the earlier event.
2. A - place your last block or ask for a photo Correct. Place and ask are parallel base-form verbs after to.

05 • Conversations

1. A bridge that can wait on the shelf - Fictional transition exchange using the lesson case.
2. The pictures are in the wrong order - Fictional visual-schedule discussion; the educator corrects two misplaced activity pictures.

3. Help with the zip, not the whole coat - Fictional self-help conversation during an unhurried dressing routine.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Outdoor time changes because of a room decision

The lead educator has moved today's planned outdoor session to the indoor movement area. The next activity afterward remains snack. Children have seen the old schedule. No weather or safety judgment is delegated to the learner.

Role A: Educator: explain the confirmed location change and update the visual sequence.

Role B: Child: ask whether snack is cancelled too.

Possible opening: The outdoor picture is still there. Why are we going to the movement area?

Success checks

- Name the confirmed location change.
- Keep snack as the following activity.
- Offer a question or choice about the transition, not a new safety decision.

Add a complication: One child assumes every activity changed because one location did.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Co-regulation and peer disagreements

Help children express needs and agree a concrete next step.

CASE

Two children reach for the same large scoop. The educator saw Ari holding it, then Bea reaching; motive is unknown. A smaller scoop is available. Ari wants to finish one container. Bea wants the large scoop next. No injury or ongoing danger is stated.

Teach this move

Use observed actions, not claims about motives or character. Co-regulation includes calm language and time to respond. A repair attempt should address the effect; a forced apology alone may not clarify the problem.

Vocabulary to check: co-regulation, turn-taking, peer conflict, repair attempt.

Model response

Ari, you were holding the large scoop; Bea, you reached for it and want a turn. Let's hear what each of you needs. Ari wants to finish one container, and Bea wants the next turn. The smaller scoop is available meanwhile. Can we agree on that order and check that both of you understand it?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision focuses on the current disagreement and a workable next action.

Second-round challenge

A child insists that wanting the same toy proves the other child was being mean.

Language-check answers

1. C - Ari held the scoop when Bea reached for it. Correct. This names the actions actually observed.
2. A - next Correct. Next identifies the following turn.

05 • Conversations

1. The large scoop's next turn - Fictional educator and Bea resolve the lesson's shared-scoop disagreement.
2. A fallen structure and a repair - Fictional accidental bump during play; no injury or disciplinary procedure.

3. A feeling word is a possibility - Fictional educator-colleague reflection on co-regulation language.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Joining a game without taking over

Two children built a pretend bus. Nia wants to join as driver, but that role is already taken; a ticket role is available and the group can discuss a later turn. No adult-assigned winner exists.

Role A: Educator: help Nia ask about participation without displacing the current player.

Role B: Nia: you want to drive but are willing to discuss another role.

Possible opening: They won't let me be the driver, so they aren't letting me play at all.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the preferred role without promising it.
- Clarify whether other participation is available.
- Support an actual invitation and a turn discussion with the group.

Add a complication: Nia treats not getting the preferred role as exclusion from every role.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Observation and family progress conversations

Describe an observed learning moment and keep wider claims proportionate.

CASE

Today educator Rosa saw Eli sort four buttons by color during a supervised activity and heard 'these go together.' A parent asks whether this proves Eli is ahead of every child his age. No comparison data or developmental screening is supplied.

Teach this move

Give the action, words, and context. Milestones and screening are not interchangeable with a single classroom observation. Do not diagnose, rank, or make universal age claims.

Vocabulary to check: observation note, learning portfolio, developmental milestone, developmental screening.

Model response

Today Eli grouped four buttons by color and said, 'These go together.' That is a useful observation of this activity, but it does not establish how he compares with every child his age. We can include the context in his learning portfolio and discuss observations over time rather than turn one moment into a developmental ranking.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised statement celebrates a concrete action without an unsupported comparison.

Second-round challenge

Ask the educator to give a diagnostic label based only on the observation.

Language-check answers

1. D - observation note Correct. The note records the child's words in the observed context.
2. D - within Correct. Within limits the evidence to its observed context.

05 • Conversations

1. Four buttons and one observation - Fictional family discussion using the lesson case.

2. A quiet group moment, an active small-group moment - Fictional educator compares two observations of participation.

3. A screening question for the right person - Fictional family asks about developmental screening; educator does not diagnose.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An undated portfolio photograph

A portfolio image shows a child completing a puzzle, but its date is missing. The educator remembers the activity but cannot verify when it happened. The family asks whether it demonstrates progress since last week.

Role A: Educator: acknowledge the missing date and limit the comparison.

Role B: Parent: ask for a current example; you do not need a diagnosis.

Possible opening: Was this after last week's observation, so we can call it progress?

Success checks

- Separate upload date from activity date.
- Avoid claiming a time trend without dates.
- Offer to check the source or discuss a dated observation.

Add a complication: A colleague assumes a newly uploaded image must be newly taken.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Inclusive participation and home languages

Compare response formats fairly and respect agreed access support.

CASE

A small-group story can use picture choices or spoken answers. Child Noor's current inclusion plan allows either. Noor prefers pointing today. A colleague treats pointing as nonparticipation. The educator can explain what both formats allow without claiming identical language evidence.

Teach this move

Different response formats can support the same activity while showing different skills. Home language is an asset. Reasonable adjustment is regional wording; U.S. settings often say reasonable accommodation. Meanings and duties vary by location. Discuss this center's agreed inclusion plan, not a universal legal entitlement.

Vocabulary to check: home language, reasonable adjustment, inclusion plan, communication preference.

Model response

Noor's inclusion plan allows picture choices or spoken answers. Both let Noor indicate a story choice, but they do not provide the same evidence of spoken English. Today Noor prefers pointing. We can recognize that participation and keep the distinction clear, instead of treating a different response format as no response at all.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The comparison recognizes participation while preserving the evidence difference.

Second-round challenge

Ask whether the same inclusion plan should automatically apply to every child.

Language-check answers

1. D - although Correct. Although preserves the contrast between participation and spoken evidence.
2. B - home-language greeting Correct. This asks for the family's actual familiar greeting.

05 • Conversations

1. A picture choice is participation - Fictional colleague exchange using the lesson case.

2. A greeting from home - Fictional family shares a familiar greeting; educator checks rather than assuming translation.

3. A quieter meeting option - Fictional family conference planning; phone or private in-person meeting available, neither chosen yet.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An adjustment mistaken for a reward

A child's agreed inclusion plan allows a quieter seating place during group time. Another adult calls it a reward that should depend on finishing a task. The lead educator can clarify the plan.

Role A: Educator: explain that this is an agreed access arrangement, not a newly offered prize.

Role B: Colleague: ask whether the child can still join the same story from that place.

Possible opening: The quieter place is in the inclusion plan; it isn't a reward for finishing first.

Success checks

- Identify the existing agreed arrangement.
- Distinguish access support from a reward.
- Ask the lead to clarify implementation without making legal claims.

Add a complication: The colleague proposes removing it before asking the lead about the plan.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Health records and factual incident handovers

Report the source and status of health information clearly.

CASE

A parent tells educator Rosa that child Theo's allergy plan may have changed. The center still has the earlier plan; no revised document is supplied. No food decision, exposure, symptoms, or emergency is part of this case. Health coordinator Amira is present and accepts the document query.

Teach this move

A family's report is important, but a possible change is not a verified care instruction. Actual health concerns require the center's real response arrangements. This lesson gives no food substitution, medication, first-aid, or emergency directions.

Vocabulary to check: allergy care plan, incident record, witness account, health coordinator.

Model response

Amira, Theo's parent reports a possible change to the allergy care plan, but we still have the earlier document and no revised plan. Could you clarify that with the family and the relevant qualified professional? I have not described the reported change as confirmed or made a food decision. Please confirm that you are taking this plan query.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised statement preserves the source and the unresolved confirmation.

Second-round challenge

A colleague wants to infer a food decision from the parent's incomplete message.

Language-check answers

1. C - account Correct. Account identifies the parent's description of events.
2. C - unverified Correct. Unverified preserves the missing confirmation.

05 · Conversations

1. A possible change to Theo's plan - Fictional document handover using the lesson case; no food, exposure, symptom, or emergency decision.
2. What the educator actually saw - Fictional resolved playground incident documentation; the lead has handled care and family response separately.
3. A health update belongs in a private conversation - Fictional parent requests privacy for a record update; no actual health advice.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A family contact attempt without an answer

Following a fictional minor incident whose care response is complete, the lead attempted the family notification at 14:00 but received no answer. Another educator is taking the communication follow-up. No care instructions or contact deadline is supplied.

Role A: Outgoing educator: report the unanswered attempt and ask for follow-up ownership.

Role B: Incoming educator: accept the contact task under the center's arrangements without calling it completed.

Possible opening: The care response is complete, but the family notification is not; the two o'clock call was unanswered.

Success checks

- Separate care response from family contact.
- Distinguish call attempt from successful notification.
- Name who accepts the contact follow-up without inventing medical advice.

Add a complication: The incoming educator sees a call entry and assumes the family already knows.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Collection, confidentiality, and safeguarding communication

Explain an unverified collection arrangement without accusing the adult or inventing legal rules.

CASE

An unfamiliar adult says they are Nia's uncle and came instead of the usual collector. Today's collection authority is not verified. Lead educator Rosa is available to check the arrangement. The child has not been released. No legal document or family relationship is established by the adult's statement.

Teach this move

Familiarity is not verified collection authority. In this fictional center, designated safeguarding lead names its child-protection contact; it is not a universal U.S. title. Follow actual local protection and reporting duties. Never promise absolute secrecy, investigate independently, or assume handing a concern to a lead replaces an individual's reporting responsibilities.

Vocabulary to check: authorized collector, attendance register, safeguarding concern, designated safeguarding lead.

Model response

I understand you have come to collect Nia, but today's collection arrangement has not been verified. Rosa can check it with you through the center's collection process. We cannot treat knowing Nia or stating a family relationship as the completed check. Nia will remain with the staff while that question is resolved.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision makes the missing verification explicit.

Second-round challenge

Point out that Nia recognizes you and ask whether that completes the check.

Language-check answers

1. B - authority Correct. Authority concerns permission for this collection.
2. B - confirmed Correct. The child has not departed with the adult.

05 · Conversations

1. A familiar face still needs a checked arrangement - Fictional collection enquiry using the lesson case.
2. The register is not a prediction - Fictional collection-time enquiry; parent has called but child remains at the center.
3. A concern cannot carry a secrecy promise - Fictional staff handover of a welfare concern; no abuse details, investigation, or legal procedure.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A parent asks about another child's incident

At collection, a parent asks for another child's name and family details after a resolved scoop disagreement. Their own child asked for the next turn; the educator clarified the order, and the child then had that turn. You may discuss those observations, not the other family's private information. Rosa can address broader concerns.

Role A: Educator: acknowledge the parent's concern while limiting disclosure.

Role B: Parent: you want to know how your own child was supported and initially ask for another family's details.

Possible opening: Tell me who the other child's parents are so I can speak to them myself.

Success checks

- Separate the private information request from the parent's legitimate concern.
- Describe support for their own child using supplied observations only.
- Offer Rosa for unresolved setting-level questions without promising secrecy about safeguarding.

Add a complication: The parent equates withholding private details with refusing to discuss their own child's experience.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

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Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics: Childcare Workers

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/personal-care-and-service/childcare-workers.htm>

National Association for the Education of Young Children: Principles of Child Development and Learning

<https://www.naeyc.org/resources/position-statements/dap/principles>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.